

# Seeking redemption in a changed world

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**W**ith Brazil's national football team, winning is never enough. For its obsessive fanbase, a graceless triumph is as good as a defeat, as Carlos Alberto Parreira found out in 1994.

After masterminding Brazil's World Cup win in the USA as head coach, Parreira was welcomed home not with accolades but with relentless barbs questioning his scrappy, pragmatic football. Even Parreira's own mother took a shot at him, criticising his team selections.

Such has been Brazil's spiralling form in recent years that its supporters would gladly embrace glory, however it comes, at the upcoming FIFA World Cup.

It has been 24 years since Brazil last played in a World Cup final. The South Americans have struggled in the tournament's knockout rounds, losing to five different European sides across the last five editions.

To make matters worse, Brazil stumbled through the South American

qualifiers this time, finishing a lowly fifth. Its ticket to North America was stamped only thanks to the resurgence sparked by Carlo Ancelotti's arrival as head coach midway through the campaign.

While there have been signs of improvement under Ancelotti, this Brazilian unit clearly lacks the might and allure of teams from the past.

At the Italian tactician's disposal is a squad thin on quality, with the centre-forward role and wing-back positions standing out as the most glaring concerns.

While Igor Thiago enjoyed a stunning Premier League season, scoring 22 goals, his lack of international experience remains a drawback. The other options are Matheus Cunha and Endrick, two players better suited to other attacking roles.

The wing-back situation is even bleaker, with Danilo, Wesley, Douglas Santos and Alex Sandro not offering the level of quality Brazil and Ancelotti are accustomed to.

Ancelotti's biggest selection call was bringing in Neymar, whose career has



## BRAZIL

**FIFA Ranking:** 6

**Appearances:** 22

**Best finish:** Champion  
(1958, 1962, 1970,  
1994 and 2002)

**Matches:** 114

**Wins:** 76

**Draws:** 19

**Losses:** 19

**Goals For:** 237

**Goals Against:** 108

**Highest scorer in the squad**  
Neymar (79 goals)



## MOROCCO

**FIFA Ranking:** 8

**Appearances:** 6

**Best finish:** Fourth place  
(2022)

**Matches:** 23

**Wins:** 5

**Losses:** 7

**Draws:** 11

**Goals For:** 20

**Goals Against:** 27

**Highest scorer in the squad**  
Ayoub El Kaabi (34 goals)

